



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Christian Heritage Academy
School Website: <https://www.christianheritage.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Christian Heritage Academy (CHA) in Northfield, IL presents a public profile that is deeply Christ-centered, with explicit integration of faith into curriculum, culture, and community life. The school clearly emphasizes Christ, Bible-based instruction, and chapel-based worship, alongside a mission of forming character and minds for service. Public materials repeatedly describe CHA as Christ-centered, with "Living Curriculum" teachers and a strong emphasis on faith-based formation through programs like GO! Week and daily chapel. At the same time, the materials show classical-inflected commitments in select areas (e.g., lower-school memory/chant practices, explicit teacher role modeling), while other classical requisites (explicit Great Books, grammar/logic/rhetoric emphasis, broad liberal arts canon) are not prominently documented in CHA's website content. Taken together, CHA is best characterized as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL: strongly Christian and formation-oriented, with solid evidence of traditional pedagogical elements in early grades and a robust community-partner stance with families, but without explicit documentation of all six classical criteria (notably the Great Books/Paideia emphasis and explicit liberal-arts Trivium/Quadrivium components in curriculum and pedagogy).

Key highlights: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are clearly present: Christ-centered instruction, Bible emphasis, chapel, and faith integration through Living Curriculum and GO! Week (evidence: "Christ-centered" language, Bible classes, and GO! Week with Matthew 28:19-20).

- School purpose and goal show formation emphasis and alignment with faith, though explicit Great Books/Paideia language is not evident; formation and mind as a gift from God are stated. - Curriculum documentation exists but does not foreground Great Books or liberal-arts nomenclature (grammar/logic/rhetoric) in the accessible public materials; history is taught, often from a biblical perspective. - Pedagogy evidences contemplative/restful elements in lower grades (memory/recitation and singing) and rhetoric/lecturing practice in upper grades in some classical education models, but explicit Socratic/seminar-based high-school pedagogy is not clearly documented.

- Faculty is presented as living exemplars in a "Living Curriculum" model, with teachers serving as mentors and role models. - Parents & community are strongly positioned as partners (the CHA parent-partnership model, "three-legged stool," and parent involvement in boards and activities).

Executive category snapshot (brief): - Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): CLASSICAL

- Element 2 (School Purpose and Goal): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 3 (School Curriculum): NOT CLASSICAL - Element 4 (Pedagogy or Teaching Methods): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Element 5 (Faculty): CLASSICAL - Element 6 (Parents & Community): CLASSICAL

General aggregate assessment: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle: To shift CHA toward a fuller CLASSICAL designation, concrete steps could include stronger articulation and integration of Great Books / paideia principles, explicit emphasis on grammar-logic-rhetoric within the curriculum (especially in middle/high school), and more explicit documentation of Socratic/seminar pedagogy in upper grades alongside continued strong faith integration and family partnership.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - CHA describes itself as “unashamedly Christ-centered” with Bible-centered classes and a liturgical rhythm (chapel, worship, and Gospel-centered activities). - The school foregrounds faith as a driver of formation, including GO! Week’s mission-centric, faith-based service, anchored in Matthew 28:19-20. - Public materials reference a faith-based worldview integrated throughout daily life and instruction (Living Curriculum).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: Christ-centered, Bible, Chapel, liturgy/-worship, faith-integrated teaching, mission-oriented language, “Rooted in Faith,” and GO! Week (which ties service to faith). These align with positive keywords such as theology, liturgy, chapel, sacred scripture, reverence, and wonder from classical lexicon.

- Negative indicators: None evident in the public materials (no secular or relativistic signaling detected). See classical lexicon for contrastive negatives (e.g., secular humanism) which CHA materials do not invoke.

Why this rating - The material demonstrates a coherent religious-metaphysical grounding with explicit Christ-centered worship and Bible integration, and a liturgical cadence (chapel, prayer, and faith-life integration) that aligns with the Classical School’s Religious and Metaphysical Foundations indicators. The absence of secular signaling strengthens this rating.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - CHA frames education as formation: “Our goal at CHA is to inspire students to see and use their mind as a gift from God—something that can be equipped to have a major impact on His world and His people beyond graduation” and a focus on forming the mind within a Christian framework. - Public materials note preparation for higher education as a trajectory but emphasize the mind’s formation and calling rather than a sole “workforce” focus. - There is emphasis on a faith-centered telos (true/beautiful/good via a Christian formation lens) even if the explicit classical lexicon (paideia, virtue, wisdom, Great Books) isn’t spelled out.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue (implicit in character formation language), wisdom (implied by formation of mind for God’s purposes), telos, classical mission concepts (though not named as such). The explicit Great Books/paideia language is not present. - Negative indicators present: none that run counter to formation and virtue-oriented aims; the school does not present a purely job-oriented or skills-first framing.

Why this rating - CHA emphasizes formation and virtue within a faith-centered teleology, which aligns with Classical School aims in spirit, even if the publicly documented vocabulary does not consistently use “virtue,” “wisdom,” or “great conversation.” The absence of explicit Great Books/paideia phrasing lowers the rating toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - CHA publicly outlines curricula by divisions (Early Education, Lower/Middle/Upper School) with Bible, Literature, Math, Science, Social Studies, World Languages, etc. However, explicit references to the liberal arts triad (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, or the Great Conversation are not documented in the accessible public materials. The materials do cite biblical perspectives in history and a broad approach to subjects, but not the classical canon framework. - One quoted curricular framing note emphasizes “Christ-centered learning” and the intent to form the mind for God, rather than a canonical classical curriculum or Great Books program. - The “Abridged Curriculum Guide” and department pages show traditional subjects (Bible, Literature, History, Math, World Languages), with a strong Bible emphasis, rather than explicit classical liberal-arts pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators from classical lexicon would include grammar/logic/rhetoric, great books, and the Great Conversation. CHA’s public content does not foreground those elements; instead, it emphasizes biblical interpretation and faith integration. This yields few explicit positive

classical keywords for Curriculum. - Negative indicators: absence of Great Books/paideia language and explicit liberal-arts cataloging (grammar, logic, rhetoric) aligns with a NOT CLASSICAL orientation for the Curriculum category.

Why this rating - Without explicit Great Books, classical Liberal Arts framing (grammar/logic/rhetoric), or explicit Great Conversation references, CHA's Curriculum does not meet the core Classical School criterion in this category based on the accessible public materials.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Lower-grade pedagogy shows contemplative, memory-oriented elements and singing/chanting-like activities in regular routines (e.g., memory verses, Chapel, Jubilate Choir, and singing as part of daily life). This aligns with the contemplative, memory-based, and liturgical facets of classical pedagogy. - Upper-grade pedagogy indicates a strong emphasis on Bible-centered learning and a broad, deep curriculum, with a focus on mind formation and academic depth. While explicit Socratic seminars are not described in the public material, there is evidence of rigorous academics and rhetoric training in upper grades (text mentions “living curriculum” and a comprehensive academic program). - The absence of explicit, widespread Socratic seminars or Paideia-style seminars in the public-facing materials lowers the score relative to a full classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: memory work, chanting, liturgical elements (Chapel), mentorship, and “living curriculum” teachers who model thinking and virtue. These map to positive keywords: memory work, chant, contemplative learning, scholé, and seminar-like engagement (to some extent) in upper grades. - Negative indicators present: lack of explicit Socratic seminars, debate culture, and explicit rhetoric-craft or Trivium-based sequencing in the publicly documented materials.

Why this rating - CHA demonstrates important classical pedagogy strands (memory/chanting in early grades; contemplative elements; living-teacher model) but lacks explicit, comprehensive documentation of Socratic/seminar-based upper-school pedagogy and explicit Trivium-based sequencing across the curriculum. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - CHA describes its faculty as “Living Curriculum” teachers who serve as role models and mentors, deeply integrated with student formation and faith integration. This reflects a classical portrait of teachers as moral exemplars and guides. - The faculty is associated with a culture of mentorship and collegiality that forms the core of the school's living curriculum and pedagogy. The public materials emphasize teacher-student relationships and faculty as a core part of the educational mission. - CHA's own communications frame teachers as partners in student development, aligning with the “portrait of a teacher” and “teachers as models of virtue” guidance in the classical lexicon.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: living curriculum, teachers as mentors/-modelers of virtue, portrait of a teacher, faculty as central to the curriculum, collegial culture. - Negative keywords (to be avoided): the CHA materials do not emphasize “facilitators” or “guides on the side” and instead stress virtue, mentorship, and exemplary teaching.

Why this rating - The explicit framing of faculty as living exemplars and the central role of teachers in delivering the curriculum align with classical expectations for the Faculty category, yielding a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - CHA explicitly positions itself as a parent-partnership school, describing the “three-legged stool” of parents, school, and church, with parents actively involved in governance and volunteering (e.g., board involvement, library volunteering). This is a strong alignment with the classical principle of “partnership with families.” - CHA blog posts outline a dedicated partnership with families, including clear articulation

of the partnership model, engagement strategies, and encouragement for parental involvement and collaboration in education. - CHA communications emphasize parent formation and ongoing engagement (e.g., encouraging families to participate in campus life, book studies, and family-centered activities as a regular practice).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with families, family involvement, parental engagement, home-school collaboration, open campus, parent formation. - Negative indicators: none evident in CHA's materials regarding parental involvement; CHA explicitly rejects consumer-model engagement by framing parents as co-teachers and partners rather than customers.

Why this rating - The public materials strongly demonstrate a robust, ongoing partnership with parents and community life, aligning with classical expectations for parental partnership and community engagement.

What Would Move the Needle

- Explicitly articulate and implement a Great Books / Paideia-style component in the upper grades, with documented references in the curriculum guide and on the website to "Great Books," "Great Conversation," and primary sources, alongside coverage of grammar, logic, and rhetoric as core progression.
- Provide public documentation of explicit Socratic/Seminars-based pedagogy in upper grades and a clear sequencing of the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across grades K–12.
- Expand discussion of virtue, wisdom, telos, and permanent things with explicit keyword usage in public materials (e.g., "virtue formation," "wisdom," "paideia," "telos," "truth, goodness, beauty" as anchored outcomes).
- Strengthen the public-facing integration of Great Books and liberal arts in the Lower/Middle/Upper School curricula, with cross-curricular projects that emphasize the liberal arts canon and Western civilizational heritage, in line with classical education models.
- Maintain and publicize the robust Parent-School Partnership framework, and consider expanding formal parent-education programs that align with classical education principles (e.g., classical literature readings, logic/grammar workshops) to deepen family formation as part of the "living curriculum."

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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